

Thejo Akkoor

Honors 493

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What's in a Name?

The color red paints my cheeks as anxiety begins to slowly permeate through my brain.

“Is it Theeyomaa—”

“Here,” I raise my hand in an ineffectual attempt to avoid the embarrassment of having my name called on the attendance sheet. I inherently curse the Spanish for their influence of the silent ‘j’ on the English community.

“It’s They-jo-maa-yi, but I go by They-jo, no silent ‘j’,” and every time, the lack of a silent ‘j’ was made up for by the unadulterated silence within which my embarrassment hung in the air.

My parents named me Thejomayi, a Sanskrit term meaning “bright and glowing”. This name was influenced by matching the ending to my older sister’s name, Hiranmayi. The further shortening of my name to Thejo, what I have always gone by, occurred quite literally before I was born. I can always distinguish those who know me and those who don’t by whether they refer to me as Thejo or Thejomayi. For the latter is reserved for strangers, substitutes, and scolding.

It started in Kindergarten: Thee-jo. Thee-yo-maya. Day-jo. Thank You. DJ. This was the first time I felt that my name that had been so lovingly uttered from the lips of my grandmother in her sing-song tone was a burden upon my identity. Being in a world of Sarahs and Hannahs, the name Thejo sounded like the unflattering product of a cough-sneeze, or the name of someone’s great uncle who sat on their American flagged porch with a beer in hand. It was not a girl’s name. And further, as if my five letter name could not be scrutinized enough, I received a Certificate commending my athleticism in P.E. back with ‘THEEJU’ written in bold capital letters. Thanks, Mr. Myrick (that’s gotta be harder to spell than Thejo).

Middle School: The Joe. Sloppy Joe. Banjo. I would soon come to realize that spending effort learning others' names was not matched by those in the task of learning mine. Thus, come middle school, the rush in my veins when the most popular girl in the 7th grade, Charlotte Richardson, addressed me *by name* was enough to reverse gravity. In this same year, my friends would come to realize that my name was fundamentally split in two parts: The and Jo. This began the proliferation of my close friends referring to me as The Joe. This would even catch on with my English teacher, Mrs. McKinney. As weird as the nickname may seem, I took no offense to this, and was instead prideful that my strange, boring name was something of interest. Being Thejo was an identity within itself. Something that I did not have to share with those around me, in fact, I think I can confidently say that the amount of Thejomayis in this world at this moment does not exceed the number 10.

High School: The Job (gotta love autocorrect). The Joke. Slayjo. Entering my diverse International Baccalaureate high-school, I felt welcomed hearing 'Gayathri', 'Kavyaranjani', and other multisyllabic immigrant names. I still experienced the anxiety of the attendance list, but felt a sense of belonging to an exclusive club, with only the most difficult experiences privy to membership. In my 10th grade English class, we read excerpts from Firoozeh Dumas' memoir, *Funny in Farsi*. This novel depicts her struggle in 1980s America with an immigrant background and foreign name. She remarks how she became "ferocious", and much later in life, "The F-word". I found solace in my plight. In a world where my younger cousins were now carrying names like Tara and Anya, I was a representation of Firoozeh's struggle. A refusal to conform. But oh boy, who knew taking a stand would be akin to wearing new-friend repellent – especially to those who weren't immigrants, and the occasional immigrant aiming to escape this seeming burden on their identity. It was a constant strive to speak up through the Zoom screen in class. Making teachers aware of my name, and my presence in their class. It was a tiresome effort, but almost every teacher in my small school knowing my name made it a worthy effort. The ability of both students and teachers alike to be able to pronounce immigrant names correctly made my highschool somewhat of an anomaly to the world, something that was a sigh of relief but also a warmth that would be stripped away from me upon entrance into college.

College. What I like to call, the Library of Judgement. Here, we are all books. Some, pretty and inviting. Others, daunting and endless. All of us, collectively, are judged by our identity on the surface from the day we enter. Hence, why having pieces of my identity that are inevitably uncontrollable (i.e. my name) perfectly paves the way for a constant battle against my “cover”. And clearly, I had seen nothing yet. Our summer orientation leader thought it would be fun to start out with a game: What are you bringing to the Potluck? The rules: state your name and a food item that starts with the same letter that you are “bringing to the potluck”. Going down the line, you have to say the name(s) of all the people before you. I had vague recollections of playing a similar game during my middle school orientation, which I recall as going exponentially better than this disaster. Dread filled my system at this moment as I looked around the room and saw a sea of blond, which was clearly going to drown me.

“I’m Ava and I’ll bring apple pie to the potluck.”

“Ava brought apples. I’m Luke and I’ll bring lemonade to the potluck.”

The line went on until, “I’m Thejo and I’ll bring tacos to the potluck.”

“Ava, apples. Luke, lemonade. Bryce, bananas... What’s your name?”

“It’s Thejo, and I said tacos.”

“Yeah, tacos. Lexi, lobster. Nate, noodles.”

Being called “yeah”, “you”, or “her” became a normal part of my life from then onwards.

This was one day, and I was able to go home after the fact to my comfort zone. Little did I know, the *actual* first week wouldn’t be much better.

“Hi, I’m Hannah. What is your name?”

“Nice to meet you Hannah, I’m Thejo.”

“Nice to meet you.” It used to be just a silent ‘j’. Now it was my entire name?

The English language is no piece of cake. Richard somehow becomes Dick. Robert, Bob. John, Jack. We bend our tongues in pronouncing Joaquin, Calliope, Penelope, and more. How were names like Thejomayi and Sushmitha any different?

“Change your name,” I recall my dad saying once at my incessant complaints regarding my tongue twister of a name. His name having 13 letters and multiple v’s in it was – to add more fuel to the fire – my middle name.

Tanya sounds much nicer, I remember thinking, but Thejo was who I was.

Changing my name would be an injustice to those who did try to learn it. Those who kept repeating it and following up on whether they were pronouncing it correctly. Those who would remark, “That’s pretty” (although I am still unsure whether I believe them or not). Changing my name would remove the bright, glowing activist inside me. It would be assimilating into a melting pot as opposed to embracing our differences as empowering. Encountering those who choose to learn my name makes up for those who choose to ignore it. My passion and drive for advocacy is a sole result of my tongue twister of a name.

Although people may assume the silent ‘j’, what they can never assume is *my* silence.